

your insurance company, and make sure the specific hospital and/or doctor you use are approved before the next medical emergency.

DID YOU KNOW?

Hospitals are required to serve and treat all patients whether they have insurance or not.

3. NEGOTIATE AND PAY CASH

Like we talked about in the chapter regarding doctor visits, if you don't have health insurance, try paying cash. Many doctors are more willing to work with you if you have the ability to pay with cold hard cash. You can also contact the financial services department and see if they have a "prompt pay" discount, which means you get a discount just for paying the bill in its entirety that day.

Even if you have insurance, a high-deductible plan is not going to cover much. Did you know you can still negotiate a lower rate? I recently read a story from a reader of GetRichSlowly.com, and she retold her experience of whittling a \$2,300 ant bite down to \$1,100. Of course, that's still a lot for an ant bite, but she scored a little more than a 50% discount just for being nice to the hospital rep on the phone.

If all else fails, there's no shame in asking to be put on a payment plan with your hospital. Most are willing to set up a plan for you interest free, which alleviates a lot of financial pressure when you can't afford to pay all in one day. Be careful, though, as you don't want to get caught up in the cycle of medical debt. Keep track of payments on your end with a payment schedule of your own. Then get rid of any debt as soon as possible!

4. DISPUTE YOUR BILL

We've all heard stories about hospitals charging for some of the most outrageous things, such as \$800 for an aspirin or \$1,000 for a doctor checking in on you for less than one minute. It's good to get these fees